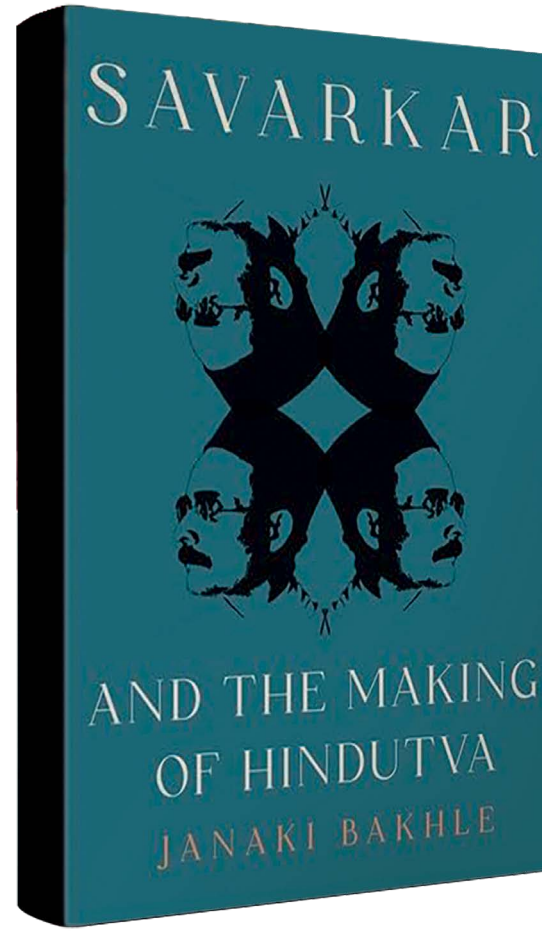
THE HINDU NATIONALIST

Janaki Bakhle's *Savarkar and the Making of Hindutva* is a deep dive into the creation of the ideologue



SAVARKAR AND THE MAKING OF HINDUTVA
by Janaki Bakhle
PRINCETON UNIVERSITY PRESS
₹999; 432 pages



Bakhle aims to paint a comprehensive picture of Savarkar's socio-political philosophy through his writings in Marathi and English

This is the latest addition to the considerable body of work—some objective, the bulk adulatory and hagiographic—on the Hindu nationalist icon V.D. Savarkar. Janaki Bakhle's endeavour is scholarly and source-based and underwritten by her fundamental disagreement with the basic thrust of Savarkar's thought. The book seeks a comprehensive picture of his political and social philosophy, looking at the entire corpus of his writings in Marathi—including a great deal of poetry—and English, which encompasses literature, history, social commentary and, of course, politics and polemics. The book, therefore, seeks to bring "the Marathi and the English sources in conversation with each other". This examination reveals a poet, a historian, a social reformer and anti-Muslim ideologue and polemicist—and how "each of these Savarkars was connected to the other".

The milestones of Savarkar's life are well known. The events from his fiery first work in English on the revolt of 1857 to his arrest in England and conviction for sedition and transportation to the Andamans comprise one segment of his life till the early 1920s. Thereafter, his conditional release following repeated petitions for clemency amidst the waning Khilafat movement; a growing intensity to his anti-Muslim and anti-Gandhi discourse; leadership of the Hindu Mahasabha; and the trial and acquittal in the Gandhi assassination conspiracy in 1948, form another. Through both stages, Savarkar had a considerable presence in the Maharashtrian mind and gradually also cemented an all-India reputation.

Bakhle notes that in the post-release phase of his life, Savarkar was not an episodic or occasional anti-Muslim, but a systemic one. To Savarkar, Gandhi's support for the Khilafat movement and the emphasis he placed on Hindu-Muslim unity proved his unsuitability to lead the national movement. Savarkar was also a prominent anti-caste protagonist. In Bakhle's analysis, Savarkar "inserted himself between Gandhi's and Ambedkar's position" while moving in a different direction to "either Gandhi's spiritual self-